the events' time and space separations, we *subtract* the squared time separation from the squared space separation, and we take the square root. (This is analogous to the Mledinans squaring the eastward and northward separations, *adding* them, and taking the square root.) As is shown in the diagrams, although your time and space separations differ from mine, we get the same final answer for the absolute interval: 0.8 kilometer.

There is only one important difference between Minkowski's formula, which you and I follow, and Pythagoras's formula, which the Mledinans follow: Our squared separations are to be subtracted rather than added. This subtraction is intimately connected to the physical difference between spacetime, which you and I are exploring, and the Earth's surface, which the Mledinans explore—but at the risk of infuriating you, I shall forgo explaining the connection, and simply refer you to the discussions in Taylor and Wheeler (1992).

As we shall see in the coming pages, gravity is produced by a curvature (a warpage) of spacetime's absolute, four-dimensional fabric, and black holes, wormholes, gravitational waves, and singularities are all constructed wholly and solely from that fabric; that is, each of them is a specific type of spacetime warpage.

Because the absolute fabric of spacetime is responsible for such fascinating phenomena, it is frustrating that you and I do not experience it in our everyday lives. The fault lies in our low-velocity technology (for example, sports cars that travel far more slowly than light). Because of our low velocities relative to each other, we experience space and time solely as separate entities, we never notice the discrepancies between the lengths and times that you and I measure (we never notice that space and time are relative), and we never notice that our relative spaces and times are unified to form spacetime's absolute, four-dimensional fabric.

Minkowski, you may recall, was the mathematics professor who had labeled Einstein a lazy dog in his student days. In 1902 Minkowski, a Russian by birth, had left the ETH in Zurich to take up a more attractive professorship in Göttingen, Germany. (Science was as international then as it is now.) In Göttingen, Minkowski studied Einstein's article on special